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An Enchanted—and Endangered—Frontier

Not many people in the Western world, or even in Asia outside the Indian subcontinent, had paid much attention to Sikkim before 1963. But the marriage in that year of the *maharajkumar*, or heir to the throne, of Sikkim, Palden Thondup Namgyal, to Hope Cooke, a 23-year-old college student from New York, changed all that. The wedding took place in the Sikkimese capital Gangtok on 20 March. Cooke was led by two Buddhist lamas and accompanied by a 'fanfare of trumpeting, 10 ft-long Himalayan horns, braying conch shells, and booming bass drums' into the Tsuklakhang Royal Chapel and Monastery, where her husband-to-be was waiting.[1] Monks did not attend the wedding ceremony itself, as marriage would lead to birth and rebirth, which are to be avoided in accordance with Buddhist cosmology. The hall was lit with butter lamps and Tibetan prayer flags fluttered from tall bamboo poles outside. Among the guests were robed Sikkimese dignitaries as well as the US ambassador, John Kenneth Galbraith, and some other foreign diplomats from New Delhi.

Hope reminisced about the wedding in her autobiography *Time Change*: 'The TV and magazine photographers running around the crowd are bowled over by all the colour and beauty'. And there were

> groups of Nepali men in bright red tunics and jodhpurs, playing widely curled horns, Sikkim guards in scarlet jackets and striped kilts…Nepali and Sikkimese women wearing different national dress, who move around together, conscious of their impact on the photographers. Sound as well as sight overwhelms one, and the movie crews with audio equipment rush from the Sikkim Police Bagpipe Band to the Indian Army Band, which has been lent for the occasion to the various villagers performing on drums and horns.[2]

On 2 December, less than eight months after the wedding, Thondup's father, Tashi Namgyal, the ruler of Sikkim, died. Thondup was the new